enormous, and some would say catastrophic, influence on him. She apparently takes part in crucial nominations.

According to sources, the government approved today the construction of over 7,000 new houses in the West Bank. A spokesman for “Peace Now” called it “spitting in the face of the United States” after Netanyahu promised the Americans to abstain from new constructions until August. Also today, Smotrich has been put in charge of civilian development in the West Bank, notwithstanding Defense Minister Gallant’s previous opposition.

These extraordinary steps may stem from the coalition’s difficulties in agreeing on the budget for next year, which has to be voted by tomorrow. Ben-Gvir, it will be remembered, threatened to leave the coalition if his demands for financing the police are not satisfied. Expansion of settlements is probably the only promise that can convince him to compromise and stay.

Friday, February 24

The budget has been approved: Ben-Gvir received 9 billion out of the 14 billion shekels he asked for. He will stay; he possibly never thought of leaving.

A former US ambassador to Israel got it right in his speech to a Democratic constituency: the Israeli government is acting cleverly in pushing its measures at a time when the US is facing a convergence of global problems: Ukraine-Russia, China, inflation, and forthcoming elections. Unfortunately, very cleverly.

Interesting article by Yuval Harari, the globally renowned professor of history at the Hebrew University in Jerusalem, in the newspaper *Yedioth Ahronoth*: his analysis of the situation is not different from the one generally heard, but when asked what he would do if the government